Big Brother

By Paula W. Peterson

My man Eugene been dead about a year and a half by now, and soon this Big Brother gonna come along. I say last thing I want around here is another man. But the social worker say Terrence suffering for lack of male companionship. Although, shoot, when his daddy was alive he didn't have hardly no more male companionship than he have now, and I don't see what difference it going to make in his life.

INTRODUCTION

Being a single-mother is difficult under the best of circumstances . . . but when you are also dealing with HIV, daily parenting issues can become completely overwhelming. In this selection Big Brother by Paula W. Peterson, Nickie is doing her best to hold it all together and has signed up with the Big Brother program for her son Terrence. Maybe a big brother can provide the stability Terrence needs. Big Brother by Paula W. Peterson.

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It true that Terrence sure be acting funny. Most evenings he too wound up to fall asleep, so he come crawl on the couch with me while I watch the news. Terrence - he big for eight year old - with a head packed with stubbornness. He always asking questions.

TERRENCE: Momma, what that lady kill her five kids for? . . . What country that? Israel? Why they screaming and throwing rocks at each other, huh?

I don't pay no attention to the TV no more. I just like to have it on 'cause it keep me from thinking too much.

I don't get no relief. Just when I fall asleep, he shake my shoulder, hard, and put his big old face right in mine until I wake up and the first thing I see is his eyes, big and brown with those long trembling lashes and he spluttering, "Momma! Momma! I think yo' skin is getting *blacker*. Wake up!"

The medications I take are changing the pigment in my skin, ain't nothing I can do about it, and it true, sometimes when I look in the mirror I think it look like I been rubbing coal on my face. Terrence worried his momma gonna turn so black she gonna disappear. So he got to keep me conscious at all times to make sure all that blackness don't swallow me up.

That child wear me out. He got a way of draining you with all his needs. Ain't it my turn to rest now, I think, ain't I been through enough already? But I know Terrence need more and I can't bring him out of this craziness on my own.. And that another reason why I say, OK, bring that Big Brother on. When I see him I think, uh-oh, what they sending me here. One of them rich white dudes trying to pretend like they's poor. You can just tell. Ain't no way this gonna work out. I bet he no more than twenty year old. Not even that.

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KEITH: Hi, I'm Keith. *(holding out his hand to shake)*

NICKIE: I'm Nickie, and this my boy, Terrence.

TERRENCE: What that say on your shirt?

KEITH: This? This says Tanglewood Music Festival. That's a . . . well, this kind of summer camp for musicians . . . back East. I used to play the piano . . . but that was a long time ago. Like in another kind of life.

TERRENCE: How come you don't play no more?

KEITH: I just gave it up, that's all. It didn't, you know, it didn't have the same kind of meaning, like, that it used to have for me.

TERRENCE: You gonna play again someday?

KEITH: *(sadly)* Maybe. I don't know . . . Probably not?

NICKIE: Terrence, quit your nosiness.

KEITH: *(shaking his head)* No, no, that's *OK*. Hey, Terrence, man, show me your room, *OK*? I bet you got a great room?

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But there are some things I need to get straight with Big Brother right away, so I say,

NICKIE: Excuse me, Keith, could I have a word with you? Now I know you know I'm HIV cause this HIV housing. But I want you to know that my boy Terrence ain't HIV, in case you was wondering. And he don't know nothing about it, neither, so I'd appreciate it if you didn't talk about that with him.

KEITH: That's cool. *(clears throat, nervously)* Terrence seems like a great, kid. I think we're gonna get along.

NICKIE: Terrence stubborn. He stubborn and he willful. . He never pay attention to what people say. If he don't do what you tell him, you come talk to me about it . . . How old you be?

KEITH: Nineteen . . . *(nervously)* Umm-hmm. And how about you, Nickie?

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NICKIE: Me? Thirty-one.

KEITH: Thirty-one. That's a great age. I'd like to be in my thirties, cause that's when you have it all together, you know what I mean?

This guy crazy, I think. After that Big Brother come once a week, and sometimes he take Terrence places like the zoo and the beach and the big playground in Golden Gate Park with the long slides Terrence like so much. Terrence bragging about him to all his school friends, I know it. Minute he get on that school bus in the morning he just busting with all the stuff he got saved up to tell, and it don't matter who he tell it to, he collar the first kid he sit next to on the bus and pin him down till the ride is over, saying, "You know what me and my Big Brother done yesterday?"

One time Big Brother bring over an electric keyboard he borrowed off of someone and teach Terrence how to play his scales. Then he play

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something for Terrence, something long and slow and soft. I listen in, standing in the hallway. Big Brother can see me, all right, but he don't let on. The music so pretty I have to hold my breath so I won't miss none. And sad. The sadness creep up on me little by little till I just standing there with my throat closed up with grief, tears ready to squeeze out. When he finish, he look up at me quickly, to make sure I'm still there.

KEITH: *(proud and excited)* I got that in my head. I remembered it. I *still* remember it, I didn't know that.

Then he sneak a glance at me just to see am I proud of him. I can't help thinking, Big Brother, do your momma know where you is? He want someone to put out cookies and milk for him. He looking at me hopefully, but I think to myself, hell, boy, don't you know that I ain't got nothing left over for nobody? That Eugene took it out of me. Took it all

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out, and then give me something I can't ever get rid of. Men is all children, it don't matter how old they are or how big they are. Unh-uhn. All that business ain't for Nickie no more.

One week Big Brother show up too early. He know that Terrence don't come home from school for another hour. I mad at *him*. I be tired and diseased and I ain't even good looking no more. I got a right to be left alone. I think, why he messing with me, anyhow? Dumb kid.

KEITH: Nickie, can I ask you a question? . . . Are you afraid of dying? . . . OK, OK, I know that's kind of personal, but I just thought I'd ask because you seem to be so strong. I think of you as the kind of person who's made her peace with death. I know you're not up at three in the morning worrying whether if you're in a coma someone's going to mistake you for dead and bury you alive . . .

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When I see you, I see someone who's so beyond that. Fear.

What this boy babbling about?

NICKIE: Where you get all these crazy ideas? What you worrying about all that bullshit for? You know how to play the piano, why don't you do that. Ain't that enough?

KEITH: What good's playing the piano. . . *(looking down at his hands, he continues softly)* I got it too, Nickie,

NICKIE: You got what?

But then, a second later, I know what he talking about and I feel bad for asking.

KEITH: *(leaning back and pinching the bridge of his nose; he shakes his head)* This is bad, man. Oh man, this is bad. *(still trying to stop crying)* Oh God, I got to stop this.

NICKIE: It ain't no death sentence no more. Look at me, I'm still kickin?'

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Maybe that just the problem, I think, suddenly. It ain't dying, it living that give us such a hard time. I don't know how to do it no more. Everything I once knew about it don't mean nothing now. My heart feel heavy. I can't go on with no pep talk.

NICKIE: Where you from, Keith?

KEITH: *(mumbling)* Hillsborough . . . Well, I used to be from there. I don't consider that to be home anymore. I mean, my parents made it pretty clear they don't want me to come back. After they found out what was wrong with me my dad told me my mom had a nervous breakdown and that, you know, she couldn't, like, bear to see me. I think my dad's pretty disgusted with me too.

NICKIE: Was you on the down low or something? *(to audience)* He don't get my meaning. I explain it to him

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KEITH: Oh. Well, just a couple of times. It was just a phase I was going through. I have this theory that we're all, like, designed to be attracted to both sexes, but the balance is different in each person. It's really interesting when you think about it . . . But I'm not gay. . . This Big Brother stuff has been great. It's really helped me change my perspective on the whole thing. Playing with Terrence, and meeting you, Nickie - just watching how you are. You're great. I mean, that first day I met you and you were so upfront about having HIV - you just *said* it. I admire that. I knew you were someone I could talk to about it. Be open. I don't - well, I don't really know anyone else who's positive.

NICKIE: Everybody I know is positive . . . And there ain't nothing to talk about.

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After that I know I got things to sort out in my mind. This Big Brother has turned into a situation on my hands. Now I know all I have to do is call the agency and they take him away, it simple. Poor Big Brother so stupid, he don't even begin to know how the world work. Thinking how stupid he be get me to feeling sorry for him, and that ain't good. Also I think, well, Terrence be much happier now that Big Brother around, and that the truth too. He chilled out a lot and he not acting up in school so much. And then I think Big Brother seem happier too, since he begun playing with Terrence. He like teaching Terrence the piano. That one thing in life he *do* know something about. . . . Who I think I am, acting like I don't need nobody or nothing?

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